restricted travel extremely impacted daily life.[21] However, if one were to encounter other accounts, western readers might be surprised to see the state-sponsored programs of solidarity and workers' protections, public support for and commemoration of antiracist and anti-imperialist causes, and various accounts of other aspects of everyday culture that had been wrongly identified as mere propaganda.[22] For example, Höhn and Klimke note, "East German leaders saw the oppression of African Americans in the United States as part of an international class struggle. … Thus they actively championed what they considered the 'other America' of black civil rights activists, focusing especially on those who shared their Marxist and socialist convictions or were engaged in international peace activities." The shared plights of African Americans and other diasporic peoples were both reflections of international counter-informational campaigns and the fabric of global networks of solidarity.

As a part of these moments of critical exchange, East German citizens regularly honored and connected with leftist African American writers, artists, and activists who made official state visits. For example, gatherings sponsored by socialist groups such as the German Peace Council (a branch of the World Peace Council) sought to protest U.S. military action in Vietnam, balancing principled critique and opportunities for propaganda.[23] This narrative is occluded from many of the Western cultural productions that fail to imagine crossing into East Berlin for reasons other than espionage, plotting escape, or reporting on stark differences between East and West.[24] Depicting the Wall as a drab and austere structure not only marked this separation but also depicted East Berlin as a metonym for the entire Eastern bloc.

Despite the decreasing frequency of overt escape attempts at the border and growing diplomatic possibilities, spy dramas were the predominant cultural mode of depicting both the Berlin Wall and East Berlin in this period. Divided Berlin was (and still is) an important site for the spy thriller of the Cold War, as the construction of the Wall brought about a cultural fascination with the transgression of the border. Siegfried Mews contends that "it may be argued that the construction and long-lasting, formidable presence of the Berlin Wall profoundly affected the spy novel: it confronted its authors with a new situation that required a reexamination of its generic properties as well as the underlying aesthetic and ideological presuppositions."[25] In such works, spies alternate between practices of